ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

MEL 101: Introduction to Modern European Languages

French and German foundations: sounds, gender and basic structures

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Modern European Languages | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack covers the first-semester foundations of French and German: pronunciation and silent letters, articles and gender, basic verb conjugation, word order, and the study habits that make a foreign language stick. It also explains how to use a dictionary properly.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Pronounce basic French and German sounds accurately.
- Use definite and indefinite articles with correct gender.
- Conjugate common verbs in the present tense.
- Build correct simple sentences in each language.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sounds and spelling

Spelling and sound diverge; learn both together.

- French: nasal vowels, liaisons and silent final consonants.
- French: accent marks affect pronunciation and meaning.
- German: umlauts, the ich and ach sounds, and final devoicing.
- German: nouns are capitalised; compounds carry meaning in parts.
- Read aloud daily; silent reading builds no pronunciation.
- Use audio from the start rather than translating word by word.

Gender, articles and agreement

Gender is grammatical, not logical.

- French: le, la, les; un, une, des.
- German: der, die, das; ein, eine, ein; cases change articles.
- Adjectives agree with the noun in gender and number.
- Word order: German places the finite verb second in main clauses.
- Negation patterns differ from English; learn them as whole phrases.
- Record nouns with their article from the first day.

> **Learn the article with the noun**
> Memorising 'Tisch' without 'der' guarantees errors later. Learn 'der Tisch' as one item.

Study routine and resources

Language learning rewards frequency over intensity.

- Twenty minutes daily beats three hours once a week.
- Use spaced repetition for vocabulary with audio.
- Speak from week one, even imperfectly.
- Keep an error log and review it weekly.
- Read a dictionary entry properly: gender, part of speech, example.
- Watch/listen to authentic material with subtitles, then without.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why learn a noun with its article?

Answer: Gender is not predictable from meaning, so the article must be memorised as part of the word.

2. What is liaison in French?

Answer: The pronunciation of a normally silent final consonant when the next word begins with a vowel or silent h.

3. Where does the finite verb sit in a German main clause?

Answer: In second position.

4. How do umlauts affect German vowels?

Answer: They change vowel quality, and often the plural or comparative form of the word.

5. Why is daily short practice better?

Answer: Frequency strengthens recall and pronunciation habits more effectively than infrequent long sessions.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn the alphabet and core sounds in each language.
- [ ] Record yourself reading a short paragraph weekly.
- [ ] Build a 100-word vocabulary list with articles.
- [ ] Conjugate five common verbs in the present.
- [ ] Write ten correct simple sentences.
- [ ] Set up a spaced-repetition deck with audio.
- [ ] Keep a weekly error log.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Faculty Primer | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

MEL 101: Introduction to Modern European Languages